DESIGN EXERCISE 2

RE-DESIGNING THE TEXT-CHATTING UI

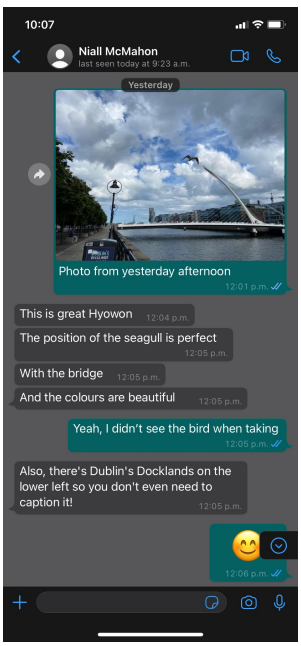
Our second design exercise is to take the guideline ‘provide short-cuts for frequent use’ and apply it to now the ubiquitous text messaging UI. This is a trio project (i.e. 3 people in a team), and the grouping must be indicated in Loop (Week 5). Those who do not input their grouping will not be graded.

DESCRIPTION

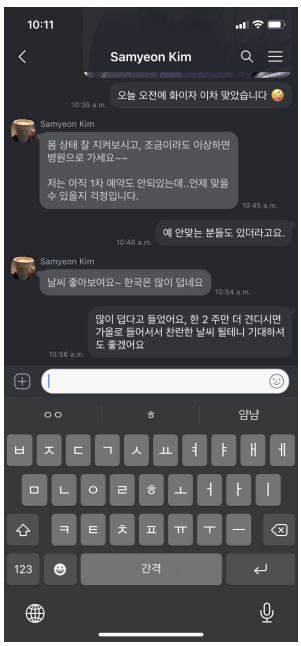
The idea of “short-cuts” is not new and has been applied and practiced for many decades in our day-to-day computing situations. Ctrl-C/-V for copy/paste in text editing, an array of toolbar buttons that brings some of the frequently-used menu items from the menu hierarchy, etc. are typical examples of short-cuts, proving extremely useful to speed up the task for the expert users.



Facebook Messenger



WhatsApp



KakaoTalk

Text-chatting UI looks like these screen shots on the left. Did you notice that ALL of their UIs look remarkably similar, with same set of features? Since this is a commonly-used interaction today, we want to consider re-designing it in terms of providing short-cuts for frequent use.

DESIGN EXERCISE 2

Here is how you can do this exercise:

(1) Find 2 other group members to work with and to submit together, input this on Loop;
(2) Open your favourite text-chat app and try to remember how you typically used it;
(3) Identify frequently-used features/functions/interaction – those that you always press or execute in high frequency when using the UI, e.g. tapping on '+' icon then insert a photo, going back to a list of chats and selecting a different chat (i.e. swapping or changing the person to chat with), using same sentences;
(4) Think about removing some steps of accessing that feature/function/interaction so that it can be done with less tapping;
(5) Sketch a sequence of UIs on any drawing tool (pen and paper, PowerPoint, Photoshop or other prototyping software): a screen that shows an initial UI, then another screen when a user taps on a particular button, and then another screen when the user taps on the bar, etc. Check on any papers/books/links to confirm your ideas and designs along the way – these can be the supporting references;
(6) Look at the sequence of UIs, then draw again a more refined version of the sequence… repeat this iteration until you are happy.
(7) Write down the description and supporting rationale for the final sequence of UIs.

Consider what we learned in the class: default values, action history, recently-opened, reduce tap distance, predict an action…

SUBMISSION

3 pages excluding title page, table of contents, references and appendices, in PDF format. Late submissions will be penalized by 20% deduction of grade per day.
Deadline: 11:59pm, 30th October 2026

The submission constitutes 20% of the module grade.

DESIGN EXERCISE 2

GRADING RUBRICS

Use the following rubrics to strengthen the submission

Criteria	Marks
Reasonable and sensible ideation for shortcut	0 - 5
Quality of final design incorporating all design guidelines/concepts learned so far (justified if not)	0 - 5
Literature and/or other hard evidences to support the ideas and design	0 - 5
Evidence of refinement/evolution of ideas/sketches/features	0 - 3
Presentation (writing, illustration, etc.)	0 - 2